From the Diary of Anne Frank

The big idea

Anne Frank was a Jewish girl who kept a diary during the Second World War. This extract, from her diary entries of **June 1942**, shows why a lonely thirteen-year-old turned to a diary as a friend, and how she cleverly turned a teacher's punishment into a joke.

BACKGROUND FACTS

- Born **12 June 1929** in Frankfurt, Germany; family moved to Amsterdam (Netherlands) in 1933 to escape the Nazis.
- Got the diary as a gift on her **13th birthday**; she named it **Kitty**.
- From July 1942 the family hid in the **"Secret Annexe"** above her father's office for about two years. They were betrayed in 1944; Anne died in a concentration camp (**Bergen-Belsen**) in early 1945.
- Her father, **Otto Frank**, the only survivor, published the diary.

Summary

- **Why a diary?** Anne says writing a diary is a strange experience — nobody will be interested in the musings of a thirteen-year-old girl. But she quotes the saying **"Paper has more patience than people."** She has loving parents, a sister of 16 and about thirty people she calls friends, but no **true friend** to share her innermost feelings. So the diary will be her friend, Kitty.
- **Her family:** Her father married at 36, her mother at 25; sister **Margot** was born in 1926 and Anne in 1929. Her grandmother died in January 1942 — Anne lights a candle for her on her birthday.

- **School worries:** The students are anxious about who will be promoted. Anne is not worried about herself except for maths.
- **Mr Keesing and the chatterbox:** Her maths teacher, **Mr Keesing**, an old fogey, is annoyed with her talking in class. He gives her extra homework:
  1. an essay on **"A Chatterbox"** — Anne argues that talking is a student's trait and she inherited it from her mother, who is equally talkative;
  2. **"An Incorrigible Chatterbox"** — she writes something original;
  3. **"'Quack, Quack, Quack,' Said Mistress Chatterback"** — with help from her friend **Sanne**, she writes a **poem** about a mother duck and a father swan who bit her ducklings to death because they quacked too much.
- Mr Keesing reads the poem in class, takes the joke in the right way, and from then on lets her talk and stops giving her extra homework.

Character of Anne

- **Sensitive and lonely** — needs a true friend.
- **Witty and intelligent** — turns punishment into humour; argues logically.
- **Honest and frank** — writes about her feelings openly.
- **Mature beyond her years** — observes adults and herself sharply.

Character of Mr Keesing

Strict but **fair and sporting**: he punished her with essays but appreciated her wit and changed his attitude.

THE THREE TOPICS, IN ORDER

A Chatterbox → An Incorrigible Chatterbox → "Quack, Quack, Quack," Said Mistress Chatterback.

MARGOT VS SANNE

Margot is Anne's sister; Sanne is the friend who helped her write the poem.

Themes and value points

- A diary can be a trusted friend for expressing feelings.
- Humour and creativity can handle conflict better than defiance.
- The pain of loneliness even in a crowd; the cruelty of war and the Holocaust in the background.
- Good teachers can accept a joke and change their minds.

LIKELY QUESTIONS

Why did Anne want to keep a diary? Why did she call it Kitty? How did she justify being talkative? What kind of teacher was Mr Keesing? "Paper has more patience than people" — explain.

Quick recap

- Diary = Kitty, gift on 13th birthday; "Paper has more patience than people".
- Loneliness despite family and friends.
- Mr Keesing's three essays; the poem won him over.
- Background: Jewish family, hiding in the Secret Annexe, Holocaust.

Practice questions

1. What name did Anne give her diary?
   (a) Margot (b) Kitty (c) Sanne (d) Keesing
2. "Paper has more patience than people" means
   (a) paper lasts longer than people (b) we can share feelings with paper without being judged or interrupted (c) people should write more (d) paper is cheaper than friends
3. Why did Mr Keesing give Anne extra homework?
   (a) She was weak in maths (b) She was absent (c) She talked too much in class (d) She was late
4. How did Anne justify being talkative in her first essay?
   (a) She said she had no friends (b) She said the teacher was boring (c) She blamed her classmates (d) She said it was a student's trait and inherited from her mother
5. Who helped Anne write the poem about the ducks?
   (a) Margot (b) Her father (c) Sanne (d) Mr Keesing
6. How did Mr Keesing react to the poem?
   (a) He sent Anne out of class (b) He complained to her parents (c) He took the joke well and stopped giving her extra homework (d) He failed her
7. Anne got the diary on her
   (a) 12th birthday (b) 13th birthday (c) 14th birthday (d) first day of school
8. Why did Anne feel she needed a diary even though she had family and friends?
9. How did Anne turn Mr Keesing's punishment into a victory? What does this show about her?

Answers: 1. b 2. b 3. c 4. d 5. c 6. c 7. b 8. see notes 9. see notes